letter ‘full of supplication and . . . excuses’[100] – along with his elephants, his standard, his banner and drums and symbols of command – and asked for permission to leave for the Middle East.

This time, Bairam did head west, into the sunset. Akbar’s court heaved a sigh of relief. Then, writes Abul Fazl, ‘a report suddenly sprung up’ that Bairam had turned towards Punjab – again! – and was in open rebellion. Abul Fazl’s explanation for this change of course is that Bairam realized, belatedly, that he had been undone by rivals in court, ‘[e]specially Maham [Anaka], who . . . was making it her business to ruin him’, and decided to avenge himself. Other historians tell a different tale.

Many of Bairam’s foes had thronged to Akbar’s court after the regent’s fall. Munim Khan, for example, having stayed away all these years after hearing of Tardi Beg’s execution, was on his way from Kabul. Pir Muhammad, having cooled his heels in Gujarat, had already galloped back east. Akbar was pleased to see him and gave him a title, Nasir-ul-Mulk, ‘friend of the realm’. His first task in this capacity was to ride after Bairam, his former master, the very man who had raised him to his former glories, and, in Badauni’s words, ‘pack him off as quickly as possible’.

Bairam Khan, the man who held on to a grudge over an elephant fight all the way from Mankot to Lahore, was furious at this final indignity. He abandoned any idea of leaving quietly and made a vengeful about-turn. War was imminent.

Once again, Akbar sent him a message, which Abul Fazl quotes in full. This third and last of Akbar’s missives to his Khan Baba is the most revealing of all – both agitated and cold, a seventeen-year-old trying to articulate his sorrow and resentment at outgrowing his mentor, his pain at having to accept the inevitability of his own adulthood, his discomfort with taking difficult decisions smothered in anger at long-ago injustices, silently endured.

‘[W]e have . . . not quarrelled with you on any matter,’ said Akbar, ‘. . . we have not gone against your advice in anything.’ And yet, did Bairam remember how his servants committed ‘murder, theft, highway robbery’ and got away with it, while Akbar’s men – he may have meant those wretched mahouts – were punished for the ‘slightest infraction’? Bairam’s men were titled ‘sultan and khan’, but others who had served the family since